# Policy & Strategy Lab

## Activity and Simulation Bank

Twenty activities, one per teaching day. The four Thursday challenges (Days 4, 9, 14 and 19) are longer simulations. Every activity uses a common case rather than participants' own cases, so that the whole room works on the same material and can compare. The case materials referred to here are in the Case Bank.

| Day | Activity | Purpose | Time | Groups |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | The ten-minute problem challenge | Experience how quickly a group jumps to solutions, then rebuild the problem properly. | 35 minutes | Pods of four |
| 2 | Problem reframing lab | Turn vague public concerns into precise, decision-focused statements, then test them against each other. | 30 minutes | Pods of four, one statement each |
| 3 | The issue tree challenge | Build a MECE tree under time pressure, then defend its logic against another pod. | 35 minutes | Pods of four |
| 4 | Root cause investigation | Separate symptoms, proximate causes and structural causes in an unfamiliar case, and defend the links. | 45 minutes (Thursday challenge) | Pods of four |
| 5 | The unintended consequences challenge | Find how a sensible-looking intervention could make things worse, and why. | 25 minutes | Pods of four |
| 6 | Follow the money | Trace how a public service is authorised, funded and delivered, from the Constitution to the citizen. | 30 minutes | Pods of four, one case per pod |
| 7 | Stakeholder negotiation simulation | Experience how power, interest and incentives shape what is feasible, by negotiating a contested policy in role. | 40 minutes | Groups of seven or eight, one role each |
| 8 | The 80/20 challenge | Practise pruning under pressure, and defend what you dropped. | 35 minutes | Pods of four |
| 9 | The hypothesis battle | Defend a hypothesis against rivals, and learn to specify evidence that would tell them apart. | 45 minutes (Thursday challenge) | Six pods or pairs, one explanation each |
| 10 | The missing data challenge | Design a feasible research plan when the ideal data do not exist. | 25 minutes | Pods of four |
| 11 | The evidence hunt | Find and rank credible sources fast, and learn which kinds of source answer which kinds of question. | 30 minutes | Pods of four, one question per pod |
| 12 | Data detective | Find what a dataset can and cannot support, including the traps hidden in it. | 30 minutes | Pods of four |
| 13 | The policy transfer challenge | Judge whether an intervention that succeeded elsewhere would work in a different context. | 30 minutes | Pods of four |
| 14 | Red team review | Stress-test each analyst's strongest finding, and practise responding to challenge without overstating. | 45 minutes (Thursday challenge) | Two pods pair up and red-team each other |
| 15 | The governing message race | Reduce a body of evidence to one defensible governing message and three key lines. | 20 minutes | Pods of four |
| 16 | Policy innovation lab | Generate a wide set of genuinely different options for a common case before choosing any. | 35 minutes | Pods of four |

| Day | Activity | Purpose | Time | Groups |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 17 | The government decision committee | Defend options before officials who judge them by different criteria. | 35 minutes | Pods present in turn; four volunteers form the committee |
| 18 | Implementation breakdown simulation | Stress-test an implementation plan against the shocks real programmes face. | 35 minutes | Pods of four |
| 19 | The five-slide challenge | Compress a complex analysis into a five-slide story with the recommendation first. | 35 minutes (Thursday challenge) | Pods of four |
| 20 | The final boardroom presentation | Present and defend a recommendation before a decision-making panel, as in professional practice. | About 12 minutes per participant | Individual presentations, grouped by pod |

# Day 1. The ten-minute problem challenge

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Experience how quickly a group jumps to solutions, then rebuild the problem properly. |
| Learning objective | Practises problem, symptom, cause and solution sort (competencies A1, A3, A4). |
| Scenario | A district runs more than twenty central and state welfare schemes. At a district grievance meeting, families from remote blocks say they receive nothing, although many appear eligible. The District Collector turns to your team: what is the problem, and what do we need to find out first? You have ten minutes. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 35 minutes |
| Materials | Scenario card; A4 sheets or one shared slide per pod; Four colours of pen or highlight, one per category |
| Expected output | Before and after statements with a named decision-maker |

**Instructions.**

1. In ten minutes, write the problem in one sentence and list what you need to find out.
2. Swap with another pod. Mark every phrase as problem, symptom, cause or solution.
3. Rewrite your own statement so it contains no cause and no solution.
4. Name the role that would act on it and the decision that role faces.
5. Be ready to read your before and after statements aloud.

**Facilitator notes.** Do not intervene in the first ten minutes. Most pods will produce a cause or a solution presented as the problem, such as a lack of awareness among beneficiaries. Read two or three first drafts aloud before the swap. In the debrief, show how a lack of awareness is a hypothesised cause, and ask what evidence would support or weaken it.

**Debrief questions.**

- How many first drafts contained a cause or a solution?
- Which word in your first draft did the most damage?
- Did naming the decision-maker change what you thought you needed to find out?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- The final statement contains no cause or solution
- The affected group and place are stated
- A role with authority is named

**Common errors.**

- Treating a lack of awareness as the problem
- Naming the government as the decision-maker
- Listing information needs without priorities

**Suggested extension.** Ask the pod to write how a frontline worker, an excluded family and the District Collector would each state the problem.

# Day 2. Problem reframing lab

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Turn vague public concerns into precise, decision-focused statements, then test them against each other. |
| Learning objective | Practises problem definition canvas (competencies A2, A3, A4). |
| Scenario | Each pod receives four vague statements. Women do not work enough in India. Our cities have a waste crisis. Government schools are failing. Farmers do not get fair prices. Make each one usable by a real decision-maker. |
| Group size | Pods of four, one statement each |
| Time | 30 minutes |
| Materials | Four statement cards; 5W1H prompt card; Canvas template |
| Expected output | Four rewritten statements; one posted for the gallery |

**Instructions.**

1. Take one statement each. Run it through 5W1H in five minutes.
2. Rewrite it with population, place, institution and period.
3. Name the role that could act and the decision it faces.
4. Pass it to the pod sceptic, who must find one remaining vagueness.
5. Agree the pod's best rewrite and post it for a gallery walk.

**Facilitator notes.** Assign pod roles for the first time today: chair, sceptic, evidence checker and scribe. They rotate weekly. Challenge any statement that still contains poor, lack of or inadequate without saying compared with what. Finish with a five-minute gallery walk.

**Debrief questions.**

- Which vague statement was hardest to make precise, and why?
- Did choosing a decision-maker force you to narrow the place?
- Where did the sceptic find vagueness you had not noticed?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Group, place, institution and period are named
- No cause or solution in the statement
- A role with authority is named

**Common errors.**

- Narrowing the place but leaving the group vague
- Replacing vagueness with an unsourced number
- Choosing a decision-maker with no authority over the issue

**Suggested extension.** Write the same problem from the point of view of the most affected group and compare the two statements.

# Day 3. The issue tree challenge

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Build a MECE tree under time pressure, then defend its logic against another pod. |
| Learning objective | Practises issue tree (mece) (competencies B1, B2, B3, F4). |
| Scenario | Suppose a state scheme that gives bicycles to girls entering secondary school is reported to have low uptake in some districts. The state department asks why. Build the tree before you know anything else. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 35 minutes |
| Materials | Sticky notes or a shared whiteboard; MECE test card |
| Expected output | A three-level tree with its splitting logic stated |

**Instructions.**

1. Agree the question at the root in five minutes.
2. Choose a splitting logic and build level one. Test it for MECE.
3. Build two more levels until every leaf is an answerable question.
4. Swap trees with another pod. Find one overlap and one gap.
5. Repair your tree and note what changed.

**Facilitator notes.** Expect first-level splits that mix logics, such as awareness, distance, family attitudes and scheme design. Ask the pod to name its logic; a mixed list cannot pass the MECE test. A supply and demand split works well here: was the bicycle offered and delivered, and was it taken up?

**Debrief questions.**

- Which first level passed the MECE test without repair, and what logic did it use?
- Where did the swap find a gap?
- Which leaf would you investigate first, and why?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- One splitting logic per level
- No overlaps or gaps at level one
- Leaves are answerable questions

**Common errors.**

- Mixing splitting logics at one level
- Leaves that are solutions rather than questions
- Stopping at two levels

**Suggested extension.** Build a driver tree: uptake equals eligible girls times the share who know, times the share who apply, times the share who receive.

# Day 4. Root cause investigation

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Separate symptoms, proximate causes and structural causes in an unfamiliar case, and defend the links. |
| Learning objective | Practises problem tree (competencies C1, C2, C5). |
| Scenario | In a stylised district, many children in government primary schools cannot read a simple paragraph by the end of Grade 3. Each pod gets eight cards: teacher vacancies; multigrade classrooms; home language differs from the textbook language; irregular attendance at harvest time; assessment focused on finishing the syllabus; low parental literacy; frequent non-teaching duties for teachers; children taught at grade level rather than at their learning level. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 45 minutes (Thursday challenge) |
| Materials | Eight cause cards per pod; A large sheet or shared board |
| Expected output | A problem tree with mechanisms and one challenged link |

**Instructions.**

1. Sort the eight cards into symptoms, proximate causes and structural causes.
2. Build a problem tree, writing the mechanism on each arrow.
3. Run one Five Whys chain from the card you trust least.
4. Present your tree in two minutes; another pod challenges one link.
5. Mark which links you would test first, and why.

**Facilitator notes.** The common trap is to place low parental literacy at the root, which puts responsibility outside the school. Ask what the school system controls. The teaching-at-grade-level card is a useful test: is it a cause, or a solution in disguise?

**Debrief questions.**

- Which card was hardest to place, and why?
- Did any pod treat a solution as a cause?
- Which link would most change the recommendation if it proved false?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Each element placed at the right level
- A mechanism on every arrow
- At least one challenged link answered

**Common errors.**

- Single-cause trees
- Arrows without mechanisms
- Treating household background as the end of the explanation

**Suggested extension.** Show how the tree would differ for a decision-maker at state level rather than district level.

# Day 5. The unintended consequences challenge

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Find how a sensible-looking intervention could make things worse, and why. |
| Learning objective | Practises causal loop diagram (competencies C3, C4, B2). |
| Scenario | A city government proposes to ban street vending on main roads to reduce congestion. Play out what might happen over twelve months for vendors, customers, traffic police, nearby shops and the roads themselves. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 25 minutes |
| Materials | Blank loop template; Actor cards: vendors, customers, police, shopkeepers, commuters |
| Expected output | A loop showing one unintended consequence, and a design fix |

**Instructions.**

1. Draw the intended chain: ban, fewer vendors, less congestion.
2. Add at least three actors' responses the planners did not intend.
3. Find one loop: a response that feeds back on the original problem.
4. Mark each link plus or minus.
5. Propose one design change that weakens the harmful loop.

**Facilitator notes.** Expect vendors to move to side streets, informal payments to rise and customers to follow the vendors. Steer pods to identify who bears the cost. If participants raise the Street Vendors Act, 2014, note that it requires town vending committees and vending zones, which changes the design space.

**Debrief questions.**

- Which unintended effect was most likely, and which most harmful?
- Whose behaviour did the planners not model?
- Does your design fix create a loop of its own?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- At least three actor responses
- One loop with polarities
- A fix that addresses the mechanism

**Common errors.**

- Listing effects without mechanisms
- Ignoring who bears the cost
- Fixes that restate the original policy

**Suggested extension.** Apply the same check to the obvious fix in your own case.

# Day 6. Follow the money

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Trace how a public service is authorised, funded and delivered, from the Constitution to the citizen. |
| Learning objective | Practises delivery chain map (competencies D1, D2, D3, D5). |
| Scenario | Each pod takes one common case: wage payments under the rural employment guarantee; school meals (PM POSHAN); staffing at primary health centres; or a city bus service. Using the Constitution, scheme guidelines and a published budget analysis, find who legislates, who administers and who pays. |
| Group size | Pods of four, one case per pod |
| Time | 30 minutes |
| Materials | Extracts of the Seventh, Eleventh and Twelfth Schedules; Scheme guideline extracts; A published budget analysis for each case; Laptops or phones for checking |
| Expected output | A delivery chain with jurisdiction, funding and a marked break point |

**Instructions.**

1. Find where the subject sits: a Union, State or Concurrent List entry, or a local government schedule.
2. Find the scheme or budget line that funds it, and the sharing pattern.
3. Map the delivery chain from ministry to citizen in five or six links.
4. Mark where delivery is most likely to break, and why.
5. Present in two minutes; another pod's evidence checker verifies one claim.

**Facilitator notes.** Participants often confuse who funds with who decides. Insist on three separate answers: who legislates, who administers, who pays. Have the evidence checker verify one claim live against the source.

**Debrief questions.**

- Where did the three kinds of power sit with different bodies?
- Which link in your chain is weakest, and what evidence would show it?
- What would a recommendation addressed to the wrong level look like?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Three kinds of power identified separately
- A funding route with a source
- A break point marked with a reason

**Common errors.**

- Treating the government as one actor
- Leaving out the local body
- Citing a budget figure without year and source

**Suggested extension.** Add the accountability institutions: who audits or reviews this service, such as the CAG, a standing committee or a social audit?

# Day 7. Stakeholder negotiation simulation

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Experience how power, interest and incentives shape what is feasible, by negotiating a contested policy in role. |
| Learning objective | Practises power-interest map with absent voices (competencies D3, D4). |
| Scenario | A large city proposes a congestion charge for private cars entering its central business district at peak hours, with the revenue going to buses. Roles: the municipal commissioner, the traffic police, a bus operators' association, a car owners' group, a street vendors' association, an environmental group, and bus commuters, who have no seat at the table unless someone gives them one. |
| Group size | Groups of seven or eight, one role each |
| Time | 40 minutes |
| Materials | Seven role cards; A power-interest grid on the board; Timer |
| Expected output | A negotiated design and a completed power-interest map |

**Instructions.**

1. Read your role card privately: interests, power and red lines.
2. Round one, ten minutes: each role states its position in one minute.
3. Round two, fifteen minutes: negotiate a workable design in coalitions.
4. The commissioner announces a decision and says whom it favours.
5. Step out of role: place every actor on the power-interest map.

**Facilitator notes.** The bus commuters' role is deliberately weak: no vote and no organisation. Watch whether anyone brings commuters into the deal. Keep strict time; negotiations drift. In the debrief, ask who was absent from the agreement and why.

**Debrief questions.**

- Whose interests shaped the final design most: power, interest or argument?
- Who was absent from the deal, and what would it take to include them?
- What will you change in your own stakeholder map after this?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Positions linked to interests
- Coalitions formed and explained
- Absent voices identified

**Common errors.**

- Treating all stakeholders as equally powerful
- Ignoring the actor who can block implementation
- Assuming the public interest is obvious

**Suggested extension.** Rerun the decision with commuters represented by an organised association. What changes?

# Day 8. The 80/20 challenge

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Practise pruning under pressure, and defend what you dropped. |
| Learning objective | Practises pruning matrix: size of effect against ability to influence (competencies B4). |
| Scenario | A municipal health department wants to reduce dengue cases this monsoon. Your pod has a tree with ten leaves: water in construction sites; household water storage; blocked drains; late case reporting by private clinics; fogging coverage; public awareness; housing for migrant workers; vacancies among surveillance staff; laboratory testing capacity; and coordination between the health and engineering departments. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 35 minutes |
| Materials | Ten leaf cards; Pruning matrix template |
| Expected output | A pruned tree: three priorities and four written reasons for cuts |

**Instructions.**

1. Rate each leaf for size of effect and ability to influence: high, medium or low.
2. Place the leaves on the pruning matrix.
3. Choose three to analyse first; prune at least four, with written reasons.
4. The pod sceptic challenges your weakest pruning decision.
5. Report your three choices and your hardest cut.

**Facilitator notes.** Pods often keep awareness because it is easy to research, and cut migrant housing because it is uncomfortable. Ask whether each cut reflects size of effect or convenience. There is no single right answer; the quality of the reasons is what counts.

**Debrief questions.**

- What was your hardest cut, and what reason did you write?
- Did any pod prune by convenience rather than importance?
- What evidence would make you restore a pruned branch?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Ratings justified
- At least four written reasons for cuts
- Priorities within the decision-maker's reach

**Common errors.**

- Keeping every branch
- Pruning without reasons
- Confusing leaves with interventions

**Suggested extension.** Re-rate the leaves from the point of view of the state health department. What changes?

# Day 9. The hypothesis battle

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Defend a hypothesis against rivals, and learn to specify evidence that would tell them apart. |
| Learning objective | Practises hypothesis register (competencies F1, F2, F3). |
| Scenario | Women's participation in paid work is low in a stylised district with growing towns. Each pod defends one explanation: care responsibilities; a lack of suitable local jobs; social norms about women's work; safety and transport; a mismatch of skills and education; or household income. Other pods will try to knock it down. |
| Group size | Six pods or pairs, one explanation each |
| Time | 45 minutes (Thursday challenge) |
| Materials | Six explanation cards; Timer; A register template on the board |
| Expected output | Six sharpened hypotheses with disconfirming tests |

**Instructions.**

1. Turn your explanation into one testable hypothesis.
2. Write the evidence that would support it and the evidence that would weaken it.
3. Present it in 90 seconds.
4. Each other pod gets one challenge: a rival explanation or a disconfirming test.
5. Revise, and name the evidence that would decide between you and your strongest rival.

**Facilitator notes.** The aim is to sharpen, not to win. Award no points for persuasion; award them for the most precise disconfirming test. Point out that several explanations can be partly true at once, which is why the register keeps rivals rather than declaring a winner. The Periodic Labour Force Survey is the obvious public source if participants ask what data could decide.

**Debrief questions.**

- Which hypothesis became most testable through challenge?
- Which rival explanations could both be true at once?
- What published data could decide between the strongest pair?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- The hypothesis is falsifiable
- Disconfirming evidence is stated
- A rival and a discriminating test are named

**Common errors.**

- Vague hypotheses that cannot fail
- Only supporting evidence offered
- Rivals rejected without evidence

**Suggested extension.** Combine two hypotheses into an interaction: when would both be needed for the effect to appear?

# Day 10. The missing data challenge

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Design a feasible research plan when the ideal data do not exist. |
| Learning objective | Practises workplan matrix: hypothesis, question, analysis, source, deadline (competencies E1, E2). |
| Scenario | A state wants to know why wage payments under the rural employment guarantee reach some workers late in a stylised district. You have four weeks, no field access and only published sources. Assume you cannot obtain worker-level payment records with reasons for delay in that time. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 25 minutes |
| Materials | Scenario card; A source menu card listing typical public sources |
| Expected output | A two-analysis plan with stated limitations |

**Instructions.**

1. Write down the ideal dataset you would want.
2. List published sources that could stand in for it, such as scheme reports, audits and studies.
3. For each, note what it can and cannot tell you.
4. Choose the two analyses that would most change the answer.
5. Write the limitation you would state in the final report.

**Facilitator notes.** The lesson is that good analysts design around data constraints rather than wishing them away. Push pods to be specific about level and period. Mention that the scheme's management information system publishes extensive data, often richer than participants expect.

**Debrief questions.**

- What did you give up by moving from the ideal to the available data?
- Which limitation would a sceptical reader find most serious?
- Did anyone find a source richer than expected?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Ideal and available data distinguished
- Two analyses chosen with reasons
- Limitation stated honestly

**Common errors.**

- Planning analyses no source can support
- Ignoring level and period
- Hiding the gap

**Suggested extension.** Design the primary research you would commission with six months and a budget, and say what it would add.

# Day 11. The evidence hunt

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Find and rank credible sources fast, and learn which kinds of source answer which kinds of question. |
| Learning objective | Practises source reliability assessment (competencies E2, E3, J5). |
| Scenario | Each pod gets one question and twenty minutes. How has the share of children in a chosen state who can read a Grade 2 text changed over the last decade? Are sanctioned posts in primary health centres in a chosen state filled? What has the CAG said about solid waste management in a chosen state? How much did a chosen state budget for school meals last year, and how much did it spend? |
| Group size | Pods of four, one question per pod |
| Time | 30 minutes |
| Materials | Question cards; Laptops or phones; Source rating card |
| Expected output | Five rated sources and the most useful one, justified |

**Instructions.**

1. Find five sources on your question in twenty minutes.
2. For each, record type, producer, period and level.
3. Rate each source's reliability, with a reason.
4. Choose the single most useful source and say why.
5. Report in two minutes; your evidence checker defends one rating.

**Facilitator notes.** Pods will start with search engines and news. Redirect them to primary sources: the survey report, the audit, the budget document. Praise the pod that finds the original table rather than a summary of it.

**Debrief questions.**

- Which source type was most useful for your question, and why?
- Did the most authoritative source answer the question at the right level?
- Where did two sources disagree, and what explains it?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Five sources found
- Type, period and level recorded
- Reliability justified

**Common errors.**

- Citing a news article about a report instead of the report
- Ignoring the reference year
- Rating by reputation alone

**Suggested extension.** Find the methods note for your best source and identify one limitation its summary did not mention.

# Day 12. Data detective

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Find what a dataset can and cannot support, including the traps hidden in it. |
| Learning objective | Practises disaggregation and comparison in a spreadsheet (competencies E4, I3, C5, J3). |
| Scenario | Each pod receives an illustrative district dataset for a school meal scheme: enrolment, meals served, days of operation and complaints, by block, for two years. Hidden in it are a misleading average, two blocks with missing months, a change in how meals were counted between the years, and a block where complaints rose after a helpline opened. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 30 minutes |
| Materials | The illustrative dataset as a spreadsheet (case bank, case 9); Laptops |
| Expected output | Three observations, two interpretations, one limitation |

**Instructions.**

1. Compute the district figure for each year, then the block figures.
2. Find where the average hides a different story.
3. Identify every missing or inconsistent value.
4. Write three observations, two interpretations and one limitation.
5. Present the claim you are most, and least, confident about.

**Facilitator notes.** Do not reveal the traps. Most pods report the average change first. Ask: is this true in every block? Then: did anything change in how the data were collected? The helpline trap is the hardest; it shows that a rise in complaints can mean better access to complain.

**Debrief questions.**

- What did the average hide?
- Which trap did your pod miss, and why?
- What claim would you put in front of a District Collector, and how would you word it?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Disaggregation done
- Traps identified
- Claims worded at the right strength

**Common errors.**

- Reporting only the average
- Missing the change in counting
- Treating more complaints as worse service

**Suggested extension.** Build one honest chart of the hidden story, with year, source and a note on missing data.

# Day 13. The policy transfer challenge

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Judge whether an intervention that succeeded elsewhere would work in a different context. |
| Learning objective | Practises comparative case matrix (competencies E5, E6). |
| Scenario | A state wants to copy a neighbouring state's apparent success in reducing teacher absence through biometric attendance, community monitoring and fewer non-teaching duties for teachers. Each pod compares the two stylised states on the conditions that made it work in the first. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 30 minutes |
| Materials | Two-state comparison cards (stylised); Comparative case matrix template |
| Expected output | A transfer judgement for each component |

**Instructions.**

1. List the components of the intervention.
2. For each, list the conditions it depended on in the original state.
3. Check whether those conditions exist in the adopting state.
4. Classify each component: transfers, transfers with adaptation, or does not transfer.
5. Write one paragraph on what to copy and what to build first.

**Facilitator notes.** Pods tend to treat the intervention as one package. Push them to separate the components, because some travel and others do not. Biometric attendance is the classic example of a form that can be copied without the supervision that makes it work.

**Debrief questions.**

- Which component depended most on local conditions?
- What would you need to build before copying?
- How would you know within six months whether the transfer was working?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Components separated
- Conditions identified for each
- A justified transfer judgement

**Common errors.**

- Copying the whole package
- Ignoring capability and leadership
- Assuming success elsewhere is proven

**Suggested extension.** Find a published evaluation of a real intervention of this kind and test your judgement against it.

# Day 14. Red team review

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Stress-test each analyst's strongest finding, and practise responding to challenge without overstating. |
| Learning objective | Practises hypothesis testing matrix (competencies F3, F5, E6, J4). |
| Scenario | Each participant presents their strongest finding in three minutes: claim, evidence and warrant. A red team from another pod challenges it with the five red team questions. The presenter then has two minutes to respond and must state any change to the claim. |
| Group size | Two pods pair up and red-team each other |
| Time | 45 minutes (Thursday challenge) |
| Materials | Red team question cards; Timer; Pod log |
| Expected output | A revised claim for each participant, in the pod log |

**Instructions.**

1. Presenter: claim, evidence and warrant in three minutes.
2. Red team: the five questions, one minute each, no speeches.
3. Presenter: respond in two minutes, conceding where right.
4. Scribe: record each challenge and response in the pod log.
5. Presenter: write the revised claim before leaving.

**Facilitator notes.** The red team's job is to improve the analysis. Stop any challenge that becomes personal. Reward concessions publicly: a presenter who says that is right, I will weaken the claim is modelling the skill.

**Debrief questions.**

- Which challenge changed a claim most?
- Which question was hardest to answer, and why?
- What did you learn about your own evidence from watching another analyst's?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Claim, evidence and warrant all stated
- Challenges are specific
- Responses concede where appropriate

**Common errors.**

- Defending every point
- Challenges that are opinions without reasons
- Revised claims that become vaguer rather than more precise

**Suggested extension.** Red-team your own decision-maker's most likely objection: write it down and answer it.

# Day 15. The governing message race

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Reduce a body of evidence to one defensible governing message and three key lines. |
| Learning objective | Practises pyramid principle with scqa (competencies I1, F4, J3). |
| Scenario | Each pod gets the same short evidence dossier on a common case: low take-up of a maternity benefit scheme in a stylised district, with six findings of mixed strength. In fifteen minutes, write the governing message and three key lines, then compare across pods. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 20 minutes |
| Materials | Evidence dossier (case bank, case 10); Pyramid template |
| Expected output | A governing message and three key lines |

**Instructions.**

1. Read the six findings and tag each as fact, inference or assumption.
2. Group them into three key lines that do not overlap.
3. Write the governing message the three key lines support.
4. Check: does any key line rest on an assumption alone?
5. Post your pyramid and compare it with the other pods'.

**Facilitator notes.** Pods will reach different governing messages from the same evidence. That is the point of the comparison: ask which message is best supported, not which is most striking. Watch for messages that are topic headings rather than claims.

**Debrief questions.**

- Why did pods reach different messages from the same evidence?
- Which governing message would best survive a sceptical official?
- Which finding did every pod leave out, and was that right?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- The governing message is a claim, not a topic
- Key lines do not overlap
- Each key line rests on evidence

**Common errors.**

- Topic headings instead of claims
- Overlapping key lines
- A message stronger than its evidence

**Suggested extension.** Rewrite the governing message for a different decision-maker: the state department rather than the district.

# Day 16. Policy innovation lab

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Generate a wide set of genuinely different options for a common case before choosing any. |
| Learning objective | Practises how might we questions with a journey map (competencies G1, G2, C4). |
| Scenario | People in remote villages of a stylised hill district travel long distances to reach a functioning primary health centre, and many delay care until they are seriously ill. Generate options for the district health officer. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 35 minutes |
| Materials | Case card with journey evidence (case bank, case 5); How Might We cards; Impact and effort grid |
| Expected output | Three distinct options and a baseline, screened |

**Instructions.**

1. Map the patient's journey from first symptom to treatment, using the case card.
2. Mark three breaks and write a How Might We question for each.
3. Generate at least eight ideas in ten minutes, without judging.
4. Group them into three options that differ in mechanism, plus a baseline.
5. Run a quick impact and effort screen. Do not choose yet.

**Facilitator notes.** Enforce the no-judging rule during ideation: the sceptic role is suspended for ten minutes, then reinstated for grouping. Pods often produce eight versions of a mobile clinic. Ask what different mechanisms exist: bringing care closer, bringing people to care, changing who provides care, or changing when people seek it.

**Debrief questions.**

- Which How Might We question produced the most different ideas?
- Which of your options changes an instrument, and which only a setting?
- What would the patient, the frontline worker and the finance officer each say about your best option?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Three options that differ in mechanism
- A do-minimum baseline
- Options traced to breaks in the journey

**Common errors.**

- Variants of one idea presented as options
- Choosing during ideation
- Options unconnected to the diagnosis

**Suggested extension.** Design a combined or sequenced option from two of your three.

# Day 17. The government decision committee

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Defend options before officials who judge them by different criteria. |
| Learning objective | Practises options appraisal matrix with a distributional row (competencies G3, G4, G5, J2). |
| Scenario | Pods present three options for the Day 16 primary healthcare case to a committee of four: a finance officer focused on cost, an implementing official focused on capacity, a representative of affected citizens focused on distribution, and a political adviser focused on support. The budget can fund one option fully or two partially. |
| Group size | Pods present in turn; four volunteers form the committee |
| Time | 35 minutes |
| Materials | Committee role cards with criteria; Scoring sheet; Budget card |
| Expected output | A committee decision with explicit weights |

**Instructions.**

1. Each pod prepares a one-minute case for each of its three options.
2. Committee members question each option on their own criterion only.
3. The committee states its weights, then scores the options.
4. The pod revises its preferred option in response.
5. Debrief: whose criterion decided the outcome?

**Facilitator notes.** Rotate committee members so several participants play roles. Insist the committee states its weights before scoring; that makes visible that the decision is a value judgement. The citizens' representative should press on who is left out.

**Debrief questions.**

- Which criterion decided the outcome, and was its weight argued or assumed?
- How did the pods' preferred options change under questioning?
- What did the citizens' representative see that the others did not?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Options defended on several criteria
- Weights stated
- Distribution addressed

**Common errors.**

- Arguing on effectiveness alone
- Ignoring the budget constraint
- Treating political feasibility as cynical rather than real

**Suggested extension.** Rerun with a different budget. Does the choice change, and why?

# Day 18. Implementation breakdown simulation

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Stress-test an implementation plan against the shocks real programmes face. |
| Learning objective | Practises theory of change (competencies H1, H2, H3, H4). |
| Scenario | Each pod has a sound plan to expand evening bus services for women workers in a stylised city. Every five minutes the facilitator draws a shock card: a budget cut; a transport union objects to new shifts; a data system fails; frontline staff are reassigned to election duty; a safety incident causes public distrust; the state changes the scheme guidelines. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 35 minutes |
| Materials | Plan card (case bank, case 7); Six shock cards; Theory of change template |
| Expected output | A revised plan and a list of the links that proved fragile |

**Instructions.**

1. Read the plan and its theory of change.
2. When a shock card is drawn, decide in three minutes how the plan adapts.
3. Record which link in the theory of change each shock hit.
4. After four shocks, redraw the plan.
5. Compare across pods: which plans bent, and which broke?

**Facilitator notes.** Draw the same shocks for every pod so that plans can be compared. The election duty card is a reminder of how often frontline capacity disappears for reasons outside the programme. Ask which risks each pod had already anticipated.

**Debrief questions.**

- Which link in the theory of change was hit most often?
- Which shock had your pod anticipated, and which not?
- What would an adaptive plan have done differently from the start?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Adaptations address the mechanism
- Fragile links identified
- The revised plan is coherent

**Common errors.**

- Adding staff or money for every shock
- Ignoring frontline responses
- Adaptations with no owner

**Suggested extension.** Add one early warning indicator for each fragile link.

# Day 19. The five-slide challenge

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Compress a complex analysis into a five-slide story with the recommendation first. |
| Learning objective | Practises indicator framework (indicator tree) (competencies H5, I2, I4). |
| Scenario | Each pod takes the evidence dossier from Day 15 (take-up of a maternity benefit scheme) and builds five slides for the district collector, following the five-slide structure. Pods then present in four minutes, not six, to raise the pressure. |
| Group size | Pods of four |
| Time | 35 minutes (Thursday challenge) |
| Materials | Evidence dossier (case bank, case 10); Slide template in the Lab's visual style |
| Expected output | Five slides with argument titles |

**Instructions.**

1. Agree the recommendation and the decision required, in one sentence.
2. Assign one slide to each member; the chair takes slide one.
3. Write argument titles: each title states the slide's claim.
4. Present in four minutes; another pod times and questions you.
5. Revise your weakest slide title.

**Facilitator notes.** Most pods will open with background. Stop them at the end of slide one if the recommendation has not appeared. Then read only the five titles aloud: do they tell the whole story? That is the test of argument titles.

**Debrief questions.**

- Did the five titles alone tell the story?
- Which slide was hardest to cut down, and why?
- What did the four-minute limit force you to drop, and was it right to drop it?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Recommendation first
- Argument titles
- Evidence and confidence shown

**Common errors.**

- Background first
- Topic titles
- Too many numbers on one slide

**Suggested extension.** Turn your five titles into a 100-word executive summary.

# Day 20. The final boardroom presentation

| Element | Detail |
|---|---|
| Purpose | Present and defend a recommendation before a decision-making panel, as in professional practice. |
| Learning objective | Practises panel presentation and defence (competencies I4, I5, J2). |
| Scenario | Each participant presents a five-slide pitch to a panel playing the decision-maker, a finance officer, an implementing official and a citizen representative. Six minutes of presentation are followed by six minutes of questions. Pods then present their synthesis slides. |
| Group size | Individual presentations, grouped by pod |
| Time | About 12 minutes per participant |
| Materials | Timer and time cards; Panel role cards and question bank; Scoring sheets |
| Expected output | A presentation, a defence and a pod synthesis slide |

**Instructions.**

1. Present your five slides in six minutes; the chair shows a card at five.
2. Answer the panel's questions for six minutes.
3. Note the question you found hardest.
4. Pods present their synthesis slide in three minutes.
5. Collect your sealed answer at the close.

**Facilitator notes.** Brief the panel beforehand: one question each, then follow-ups, no speeches, no hostile questioning. With more than about nine participants, run two parallel panels or extend the session. Keep strict time.

**Debrief questions.**

- Which question exposed something your analysis had not covered?
- Where did you concede, and did it cost you?
- What will you change in the client report before it is due?

**Evaluation criteria.**

- Recommendation in the first minute
- Direct, evidenced answers
- Uncertainty conceded where warranted

**Common errors.**

- Background first
- Defending every point
- Reading slides aloud

**Suggested extension.** Write the paragraph you wish you had given in answer to the hardest question, and put it in the report.